fine. Physical pain is preferable to losing. I know how to deal with physical pain.

Eranga's action is hard to read – the ball tends to feel like it catapults from nowhere, extracting pace out of the wicket in odd moments, causing the ball to spit, often in the throat area. I know the ball will be in one of two places – my toes, or my head. He runs in to bowl his first ball. I am exhausted from everything that has happened over the past two weeks, every mind-bending passage of play and yet, whatever happens in the next five minutes is the only thing that will matter. It will entirely frame everything that has come before it.

My eyes are enormous, half startled, half manically focused, my tongue pressing on my top lip. The first ball is short, quick, just outside off stump. I must be sensing everything in hyper-real motion because I feel like I have almost too much time to watch it. I get inside it, block the ball relatively safely. It rolls to the man at bat-pad. As it does, it is like my peripheral vision widens and a tunnel I've been travelling through has opened up. There are so many fielders surrounding the bat. Survived one, five to go. I take a breath and walk away from the crease to calm myself down. The entire scope of a summer is inside this moment, the crowd holding their breath with me, the sky dark and tense.

I settle back at the crease, the sky darkens again, the tunnel my only focus. The second ball is similar. I watch it and guide it safely to gully. Two gone, four to go. Eranga comes over the wicket for his third ball. It's a change of angle, trying to cramp me for space. As he runs in, I wonder if my eyebrows look as inward-facing as they feel they are, whether it appears as my senses tell me, like parts of my face are being pulled all over the place, distorting and imploding like a Picasso. It all feels so life and death. Nothing could be more important than surviving here. It's another short ball that I watch, surprising myself again with the amount of time I have to see it, and again block it. The fourth ball of the over, I'm convinced that this time he will try to bowl fuller given that he has me going back and across, on to my stumps with each short ball. The tunnel encloses. I'm right, I get right in behind and block it. Two to come.

There is a horrible nervous energy that comes with batting. Of all the disciplines in all the sports, for some reason, batting is the one that I have never been able to make feel natural. I play golf right-handed, I bowl right-